A PUBLIC CONVERSATION ABOUT LAND & JUSTICE

BEYOND THE ACKNOWLEDGMENT

Who owns the land —
and who gets to decide?

A student reflection on Indigenous land, property rights, and conservation

ECON 238

A land acknowledgment names a history. But what changes after the statement?

RECOGNITION

Acknowledgments can make Indigenous history more visible and encourage people to ask whose land they are on. It seeks to recognize those who have stewarded the land of which we use.

OWNERSHIP

A statement does not, by itself, change legal title, decision-making power, or access to resources. Nor does it justly compensate for the hardships forced upon the native peoples as their land was taken from them.

ACTION

Partnerships, funding, conservation agreements, and greater tribal authority can create material change.

The question isn't only “What do we acknowledge?”
It's also “What are we willing to change?”

When ownership is complicated, opportunity can be too.

COMPLICATED OWNERSHIP
Multiple claims and layers of oversight

→

HIGHER TRANSACTION COSTS
More time, uncertainty, and coordination

→

FEWER INVESTMENT OPTIONS
Projects may be harder to finance or approve

→

LOST OPPORTUNITY?
Jobs, revenue, or services may not arrive

This is one reason tribal sovereignty and clear property rights matter economically — not just symbolically.

But development isn't one-size-fits-all. Location, resources, tribal priorities, and local institutions all matter.

Tribal ownership does not mean economic inactivity.

The Squamish Nation's high-rise development in Vancouver is a useful reminder: tribal governments can pursue major development when they have authority over land and the ability to make decisions.

The broader lesson: self-determination can include conservation, tourism, housing, business, or a mix of uses.

A QUESTION WORTH ASKING

What if the issue isn't whether tribes can manage land — but whether they have had the authority and resources to choose how?

Agency changes the set of available choices.

What would it mean to return a park — and its decisions?

THE CASE FOR CHANGE

Some parks were created after Indigenous communities were displaced. Returning authority could recognize that history and expand tribal self-determination.

THE PRACTICAL QUESTIONS

Who sets visitor limits and fees? How are conservation costs funded? What happens when multiple tribes have claims or different priorities?

A POSSIBLE START

Co-management, shared revenue, or carefully designed pilot agreements could test what works before broader transfers.

Tribal parks described in the assignment show that conservation, cultural education, and local economic activity can coexist — though outcomes will depend on the specific place and governance model.

If we mean it, what would we measure?

01 TRIBAL AUTHORITY

Are Indigenous communities making real decisions about land and resources?

02 ECONOMIC BENEFIT

Do partnerships create lasting revenue, jobs, and opportunities chosen by tribes?

03 CONSERVATION

Are ecosystems protected over time, with transparent goals and monitoring?

04 PUBLIC ACCESS

Can access remain fair while respecting cultural priorities and environmental limits?

A land acknowledgment can start a conversation. The harder question is what comes next.

Based on the ECON 238 Week Nine assignment and the student's discussion of Questions 7–12.